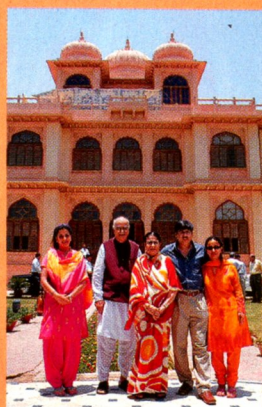


to have been reserved for the very end

he was not in the know of the decision to release terrorists. His claim was contested by Singh as well as then defence minister George Fernandes, both of whom said Advani was present at the Cabinet meeting where the decision was taken. Further embarrassment was in store when Advani claimed he had spoken to US ambassador Robert Blackwill seeking American help to end the crisis, but the latter denied



screaming headlines back home and much breast-beating in the party. Advani resigned but was "persuaded" to withdraw his resignation. In December, he stepped down as party president at the end of his tenure and was succeeded by Rajnath Singh. Later, in a TV interview, Advani said that in the tradition of parliamentary democracy, he was the BJP's prime ministerial candidate. His claim was endorsed by Vajpayee, by then ailing. The toughest test in his political career seems to have been reserved for the very end.



it, saying he was posted to India a full two years later.

2005 The Father

of Hindutva went to the land of his birth and stood everything that he and his party had stood for all these years on its head. Visiting the mausoleum of Jinnah, he termed the father of Partition as a "secularist". There were



SIPRA DAS

talks Hindutva in his stump speeches. Was defending Varun Gandhi worth the effort? You could have let him go."

"I would have invited another kind of controversy within our own support base. For the sake of the image, you cannot push aside practical wisdom. The party has totally disowned what he has reportedly said. The Election Commission has exceeded its power. The invocation of National Security Act to deal with him was politically perverse. I didn't compare him to JP. I simply said that you invoked draconian laws against an electoral opponent thinking that he would lose the election from a prison. George Fernandes and Nanaji Deshmukh won handsomely from behind the bars. And look at the political consequence. It has become a battle between the BJP and the BSP, with the latter taking all these steps in order to satisfy the Muslim electorate."

The big question is: has Advani seized the moment? He has the context: an India under attack and the gloom in the marketplace.

Has he got a text? An inspirational campaign theme that can turn the groundswell of disillusion into a movement for change? He and his managers continue to believe that he is all set to bring an end to politics-as-usual. He has already asked his brain trust to "work out what should be done in the first 100 days". His broad objective is to "replace the prevailing sense of cynicism and hopelessness with popular confidence in a government that cares".

When he reaches Pandharpur, the first stop in his Maharashtra tour, it is the drumbats of hope that welcome the man who aspires to be the redeemer. It is already late in the evening and he has one more rally to address at Shivgaon. He is inspired; he wants to tell them the story about an unpopular sultan who once ruled the region. When a famine struck the area, thousands died. The sultan's granaries were full. His saintly minister who was revered by the people opened the khazana and everyone was overjoyed but not the sultan. He asked the minister to compensate for the loss. Finally, a divine intervention brought an end to the arrogance and heartlessness of the ruler. "A good king is the one who cares, and if I become prime minister, I'll be India's first *sevak*." And now Advani himself is beating the drum, a rare performance from the candidate.

Once, such performances only marked the ascent of the nationalist who based his entire argument on Hindutva.

CANDIDATE

Advani is a man who has migrated from the backyard of mythology to the frontline of technology at the click of a mouse.

